

## Promises and Pressure: The First Promise

### 承诺与压力：第一次承诺

Theme: 友谊、家庭与人际关系 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6, 127

#### English Story

The collision happened on a Sunday. Lin's **mother** was in the hospital **ward** where his grandmother had worked as a **nurse**, and the project meeting was at the same hour. “**What** do you expect me to say?” he asked. “That the study is more **faithful** than a family?” His **sister** said nothing; his **brother** laughed. The **photograph** on the wall — a wedding in **black** and white, a **honeymoon** in the hills — was the only picture there.

The **elder** of the family, his grandfather, had been an **orphan**; the **orphanage** had given him a name and very little else. “A **parent** is a **person**,” he said. “Not an **objective**.” Lin felt the old **fear** of being **superficial** — an **acquaintance** of everyone, attached to no one. The word **isolation** pierced him more than the argument did, and something in his **soul** went quiet.

His **mother's** **voice** was quiet too. “You have a **domestic** heart,” she said, “and a research heart, and only one **portion** of **attention**.” She spoke about **influence**, **connection**, **attachment**, and the slow **transference** of love from one generation to the next. A **relative** would have agreed. A **pet rat** in a **junior class**, a quarrel between lovers in the dormitory, a **marriage** that had held for thirty years: all of it belonged to the same study of how people keep promises.

They agreed on three roles and wrote them on the back of a **photograph**: Lin would come home every second Sunday; Maya would **host** the Thursday meeting alone; the group would **embrace** a smaller scope until the spring. “This is not a separation,” Maya said. “It is a renegotiation, and a **confidential** one if you need it to be.” **Confucianism**, she added, had a word for it, but the plain word was enough. The **orientation** of the whole project changed by a few degrees that afternoon.

He kept that promise five weeks. The book he was reading, the class he was teaching, the example of good practice set by the department: none of it mattered on the Sunday his grandfather died. His **mother** said only that she was glad he had come. “A **voice** on the telephone is not a **person**,” she said. “You know that better than your **father** did.” He wrote it down in the language he used for research, and then he wrote it again in his own, because the first version was the method talking and the second was him. Of course the group understood it: the project could not **arouse** the interest of a **grandparent** by itself, and the **adoption** of a smaller scope was the only honest sort of promise. They taught themselves to turn toward the people in the room.

#### 中文翻译

冲突出现在一个周日。林伟的母亲在医院的病房里——他祖母曾在那里当护士——而项目会议正好在同一时间。“你想让我说什么？”他问。“说研究比家庭更忠实？”他妹妹什么也没说，他哥哥笑了。墙上那张照片——一场黑白婚礼、一次山间蜜月——是屋里唯一的画。

家里的长辈、他的祖父，曾是个孤儿；孤儿院给了他一个名字，别的东西很少。“父母是人，”他说，“不是一个目标。”林伟感到那种古老的恐惧：成为一个肤浅的人——认识所有人，却谁也不亲近。“隔绝”这个词比争论更刺穿了他，而他灵魂里的某样东西安静了下来。

他母亲的声音也很轻。“你有一颗家庭的心，”她说，“也有一颗研究的心，而注意力只有一份。”她谈到影响力、联系、依恋，以及爱如何一代一代缓慢转移。任何一位亲戚都会说同样的话。少年班教室里的一只宠物鼠、宿舍里情人的争吵、维持了三十年的婚姻：所有这些都属于同一项关于人如何守信的研究。

他们定了三个角色，写在一张照片的背面：林伟每隔一个周日回家；曼雅独自主持周四的会议；小组把范围缩到春天为止。“这不是分开，”曼雅说，“这是一次重新商定；如果你需要，它也可以是保密的。”她补充说，儒家思想里有一个词专门说这件事，但用平常的话就够了。整个项目的方向在那个下午偏转了几度。

他坚持了五个星期。他正在读的书、他教的课、系里当作良好实践的例子：在他祖父去世的那个周日，这些都不重要了。他母亲只说，她很高兴他回来了。“电话里的声音不是一个人，”她说，“这一点你比你父亲明白。”他用做研究时的语言把它写了下来，然后又用自己的语言写了一遍——因为第一版是方法在说话，第二版才是他。当然，小组明白这一点：这个项目本身唤不起一位长辈的兴趣，而缩小范围是唯一诚实的承诺方式。他们学着把注意力转向屋子里的那些人。

## Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

| Word / Pronunciation                       | Context meaning / source example                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>what</b><br>hwɒt<br>POS: pron           | pron. 什么; interj. 怎么, 多么; a. 什么的; adv. 到什么程度<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: pron., a., & adv. As an interrogative pronoun, used in asking; questions regarding either persons or things...           |
| <b>mother</b><br>ˈmʌðə<br>POS: n           | n. 母亲, 修女院长; vt. 产生, 照看, 收养<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a woman who has given birth to a child (also used as a term of address to your mother); n. a stringy slimy...                          |
| <b>black</b><br>blæk<br>POS: n             | n. 黑色, 黑颜料; a. 黑色的<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the quality or state of the achromatic color of least lightness (bearing the least resemblance to white); n...                                  |
| <b>father</b><br>ˈfɑːðə<br>POS: n          | n. 父亲, 祖先, 长辈, 神父, 创始者; vt. 当...的父亲, 保护, 创作, 发明, 培养<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a male parent (also used as a term of address to your father); n. 'Father' is a term of address for priests... |
| <b>person</b><br>ˈpɜːsn<br>POS: n          | n. 人, 人身, 人称; [法] 人, 法人, 人身<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a human being; n. a human body (usually including the clothing); n. a grammatical category used in the class...                        |
| <b>parent</b><br>ˈperənt<br>POS: n         | n. 父母, 父母亲, 根源; [法] 父亲, 母亲, 根源<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a father or mother; one who begets or one who gives birth to or nurtures and raises a child; a relative wh...                       |
| <b>voice</b><br>vɔɪs<br>POS: n             | n. 声音, 嗓音, 嗓子, 愿望, 发言权, 表达, 喉舌, 语态; vt. 表达, 吐露, 调音<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the distinctive quality or pitch or condition of a person's speech; n. the sound made by the vibration of v...  |
| <b>attention</b><br>əˈtenʃən<br>POS: n     | n. 注意, 注意力; [计] 引起注意信号<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the process whereby a person concentrates on some features of the environment to the (relative) exclusion...                                |
| <b>brother</b><br>ˈbrʌðə<br>POS: n         | n. 兄弟<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a male with the same parents as someone else; n. a male person who is a fellow member (of a fraternity or r...                                               |
| <b>sister</b><br>ˈsɪstə<br>POS: n          | n. 姐妹, 姐, 妹, 护士, 修女; vt. 姐妹般对待<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a female person who has the same parents as another person; n. (Roman Catholic Church) a title given to a n...                      |
| <b>fear</b><br>fiə<br>POS: n               | n. 恐怖, 害怕, 担心; v. 害怕, 恐惧, 为...担心, 敬畏<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. an emotion experienced in anticipation of some specific pain or danger (usually accompanied by a desire to...                 |
| <b>marriage</b><br>ˈmæridʒ<br>POS: n       | n. 婚姻, 结婚, 婚礼, 合并; [医] 婚姻, 结婚<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the state of being a married couple voluntarily joined for life (or until divorce); n. two people who are m...                       |
| <b>influence</b><br>ˈɪnfluəns<br>POS: n    | n. 影响力, 权力, 势力; vt. 影响, 改变<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a power to affect persons or events especially power based on prestige etc; n. causing something without an...                          |
| <b>objective</b><br>əbˈdʒektɪv<br>POS: n   | n. 目的, 目标, 宗旨, 宾格, 实物; a. 客观的, 如实的, 无偏见的, 宾格的<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the lens or system of lenses in a telescope or microscope that is nearest the object being viewed; a. undis...       |
| <b>domestic</b><br>dəʊˈmestɪk<br>POS: a    | a. 家庭的, 国内的, 驯养的; [医] 家庭的, 家用的<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a servant who is paid to perform menial tasks around the household; a. of concern to or concerning the inte...                      |
| <b>connection</b><br>kəˈnekʃən<br>POS: n   | n. 连接, 关系, 前后关系; [计] 连接<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a relation between things or events (as in the case of one causing the other or sharing features with it); ...                             |
| <b>photograph</b><br>ˈfəʊtəɡrɑːf<br>POS: n | n. 相片, 照片, 逼真的描绘; v. 照相, 摄影<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a representation of a person or scene in the form of a print or transparent slide; recorded by a camera on...                          |
| <b>soul</b><br>səʊl<br>POS: n              | n. 灵魂, 心灵, 精神, 精髓, 人, 化身, 典型, 鬼魂; a. 黑人的<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the immaterial part of a person; the actuating cause of an individual life; n. deep feeling or emotion; n. t...           |
| <b>nurse</b><br>nɜːs<br>POS: n             | n. 护士, 保姆, 奶妈; vt. 看护, 照顾, 培养; vi. 喂奶, 看护病人<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. one skilled in caring for young children or the sick (usually under the supervision of a physician); v. try...         |

| Word / Pronunciation                           | Context meaning / source example                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>host</b><br>heʊst<br>POS: n                 | n. 主人, 旅馆老板, 节目主持人; vt. 当主人招待, 作...节目主持人; [计] 主机, 宿主机<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a person who invites guests to a social event (such as a party in his or her own home) and who is responsi...                       |
| <b>portion</b><br>'pɔ:ʃən<br>POS: n            | n. 部分, 一份, 命运, 嫁妆; vt. 分配, 给...嫁妆<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. something determined in relation to something that includes it; n. something less than the whole of a human a...                                        |
| <b>relative</b><br>'relatɪv<br>POS: n          | n. 亲戚, 关系词; a. 有关系的, 相对的, 比较的<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a person related by blood or marriage; n. an animal or plant that bears a relationship to another (as relat...                                              |
| <b>junior</b><br>'dʒu:njə<br>POS: n            | n. 年少者, 地位较低者, 大学三年级学生; a. 年少的, 下级的, 后进的<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. term of address for a disrespectful and annoying male; n. a third-year undergraduate; n. the younger of two...                                   |
| <b>embrace</b><br>im'breɪs<br>POS: n           | n. 拥抱; vt. 拥抱, 互相拥抱, 包含, 收买; vi. 拥抱<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the act of clasping another person in the arms (as in greeting or affection); n. the state of taking in or...                                         |
| <b>lover</b><br>'lʌvə<br>POS: n                | n. 爱人, 爱好者<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a person who loves someone or is loved by someone; n. a significant other to whom you are not related by ma...                                                                 |
| <b>ward</b><br>wɔ:d<br>POS: n                  | n. 病房, 守卫, 保卫, 保护, 监护, 牢房, 行政区, 锁孔内的榫舌; vt. 使入病房, 守护, 保卫<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a person who is under the protection or in the custody of another; n. a district into which a city or town...                    |
| <b>rat</b><br>ræt<br>POS: n                    | n. 鼠, 卑鄙的人, 破坏者, 变节者; vi. 捕鼠, 变节; vt. 弄蓬松<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. any of various long-tailed rodents similar to but larger than a mouse; n. a pad (usually made of hair) worn...                                  |
| <b>orientation</b><br>ˌɔ:riən'teɪʃən<br>POS: n | n. 定方位, 适应, 向东方; n. 方向; [计] 方向<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the act of orienting; n. an integrated set of attitudes and beliefs; n. position or alignment relative to po...                                            |
| <b>pet</b><br>pet<br>POS: n                    | n. 宠物, 受宠爱的人, 宠坏的孩子, 不悦, 生气; a. 宠爱的, 表示亲昵的, 养着观赏的, 特别珍爱的, 格外的; vt. 宠爱, ...<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a domesticated animal kept for companionship or amusement; n. a fit of petulance or sulkiness (especially a... |
| <b>isolation</b><br>ˌaɪsə'leɪʃən<br>POS: n     | n. 隔绝, 孤立, 隔离; [化] 分离; 生物分离<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a state of separation between persons or groups; n. a feeling of being disliked and alone; n. the act of iso...                                               |
| <b>adoption</b><br>ə'dɒpʃən<br>POS: n          | n. 采用, 采纳, 收养; [法] 收养, 采纳, 采用<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the act of accepting with approval; favorable reception; n. a legal proceeding that creates a parent-child...                                               |
| <b>elder</b><br>'eldə<br>POS: n                | n. 年长者, 老人, 前辈; a. 年长的, 资深的<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a person who is older than you are; n. any of numerous shrubs or small trees of temperate and subtropical n...                                                |
| <b>arouse</b><br>ə'raʊz<br>POS: vt             | vt. 唤醒, 鼓励, 引起; vi. 醒来<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: v. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses); v. to begin moving. "As the thunder started the sleeping ch...                                                     |
| <b>grandparent</b><br>'grændperənt<br>POS: n   | n. 祖父母<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a parent of your father or mother                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>faithful</b><br>'feɪθfʊl<br>POS: a          | a. 忠实的, 详确的, 可靠的; n. 信徒<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. any loyal and steadfast following; a. steadfast in affection or allegiance; a. not having sexual relations w...                                                   |
| <b>confidential</b><br>ˌkɒnfɪ'denʃəl<br>POS: a | a. 机密的, 获他人信赖的, 易于信任他人的; [经] 秘密件<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: s. entrusted with private information and the confidence of another; s. (of information) given in confidence o...                                           |
| <b>attachment</b><br>ə'tʃætmənt<br>POS: n      | n. 连接, 附属物, 连接物, 爱慕; [计] 附加, 附件<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a feeling of affection for a person or an institution; n. a supplementary part or accessory; n. a writ autho...                                           |
| <b>acquaintance</b><br>ə'kweɪntəns<br>POS: n   | n. 认识, 相识者<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. personal knowledge or information about someone or something; n. a relationship less intimate than friendsh...                                                                 |
| <b>superficial</b><br>ˌsju:pe'fɪʃəl<br>POS: n  | n. 表面, 外表; a. 表面的, 肤浅的, 面积的<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: a. concerned with or comprehending only what is apparent or obvious; not deep or penetrating emotionally or i...                                                 |

| Word / Pronunciation                                  | Context meaning / source example                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>pierce</b><br>piəs<br>POS: vt                      | vt. 刺穿, 穿透, 打眼于, 洞悉, (声音)响彻, (亮光)照进, 深深地打动; vi. 刺入, 穿入, 透入, 进入<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. 14th President of the United States (1804-1869); v. cut or make a way through; v. move or affect (a person's... |
| <b>orphan</b><br>'ɔ:fən<br>POS: n                     | n. 孤儿; a. 无双亲的, 孤儿的; vt. 使成孤儿; [计] 弧体<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a child who has lost both parents; n. someone or something who lacks support or care or supervision; n. the...                           |
| <b>honeymoon</b><br>'hʌnimu:n<br>POS: n               | n. 蜜月, 蜜月假期; vi. 渡蜜月<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. a holiday taken by a newly married couple; n. the early (usually calm and harmonious) period of a relations...                                            |
| <b>orphanage</b><br>'ɔ:fənidʒ<br>POS: n               | n. 孤儿院, 孤儿身份; [法] 孤儿身份, 孤儿, 孤儿院<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the condition of being a child without living parents; n. a public institution for the care of orphans                                         |
| <b>transference</b><br>træns'fɜ:rens<br>POS: n        | n. 转移, 调动, 转让; [医] 转移; 情感转移<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. (psychoanalysis) the process whereby emotions are passed on or displaced from one person to another; durin...                                      |
| <b>confucianism</b><br>kən'fju:ʃjənizɪzɪzɪm<br>POS: n | n. 孔子思想, 儒家思想<br>Collocation: — (not independently sourced)<br>Example: n. the teachings of Confucius emphasizing love for humanity; high value given to learning and to devotion to...                                                     |